

## References for ES and MS teachers

SPIRIT OF THE WIND (movie) curriculum

ALASKA SPORTS HALL OF FAME Healthy Heros Program Feature about George Attla

# **SPIRIT OF THE WIND: An instructional unit in Alaska State History**

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## **Introduction:**

SPIRIT OF THE WIND: An instructional unit in Alaska State History is a stand-alone unit incorporating elements and readings about George Attla, perhaps the most famous Alaska musher ever. Aspects of his and Athabascan life and culture are explored through viewing *Spirit of the Wind*, George's story up to 1979, plus related readings.

This instructional unit is not designed as a complete semester-long course in Alaska state history. Rather, it addresses selected aspects of the body of knowledge expected of students completing such a course. It can be used to augment an existing course or as an introduction to Alaska state history.

The elements of Alaska history recognized by the Alaska Board of Education as needed in such a course are listed below. This unit focuses, in part, on aspects of Alaska geography, Alaska's cultures, and modern Alaska.

## **High School Graduation Requirement:**

After a statewide advocacy effort, led by the Alaska Humanities Forum, the State Board of Education amended 4AAC 06.075. This regulation now requires that as of January 1, 2009, the three units of social studies required for graduation must include one-half unit of credit in Alaska history or demonstration that the student meets the Alaska history performance standards. This does not apply to a student (1) who transfers into an Alaska public school after the student's second year of high school or (2) has already successfully completed a high school state history course from another state.

## **Some elements of Alaska state history:**

- Geography: <http://www.akhistorycourse.org/articles/article.php?artID=313>
- Alaska's Cultures: <http://www.akhistorycourse.org/articles/article.php?artID=315>
- Russia's Colony: <http://www.akhistorycourse.org/articles/article.php?artID=316>
- America's Territory: <http://www.akhistorycourse.org/articles/article.php?artID=316>
- Governing Alaska- <http://www.akhistorycourse.org/articles/article.php?artID=318>
- Modern Alaska: <http://www.akhistorycourse.org/articles/article.php?artID=318>

## **Materials for the unit:**

Spirit of the Wind: the life of George Attla and his sled dog racing

Study Guide with additional references to:

George Attla  
tuberculosis  
dog racing  
trapping  
subsistence fishing  
boarding schools  
the Molly Hootsch decision  
the relocation of Alaska bush villages

Reading assignments and focus questions for the student to address

An "open book" written assessment

## **Alaska Native Heritage Center**

### **ATHABASCANS**

01-01-2000

#### **Who We Are**



The Athabascans traditionally lived in Interior Alaska, an expansive region that begins south of the Brooks Mountain Range and continues down to the Kenai Peninsula. There are eleven linguistic groups of Athabascans in Alaska. Athabaskan people have traditionally lived along five major river ways: the Yukon, the Tanana, the Susitna, the Kuskokwim, and the Copper river drainages. Athabascans were highly nomadic, traveling in small groups to fish, hunt and trap.

Today, Athabascans live throughout Alaska and the Lower 48, returning to their home territories to harvest traditional resources. The Athabaskan people call themselves 'Dena,' or 'the people.' In traditional and contemporary practices Athabascans are taught respect for all living things. The most important part of Athabaskan subsistence living is sharing. All hunters are part of a kin-based network in which they are expected to follow traditional customs for sharing in the community.

#### **House Types and Settlements**

The Athabascans traditionally lived in small groups of 20 to 40 people that moved systematically through the resource territories. Annual summer fish camps for the entire family and winter villages served as base camps. Depending on the season and regional resources, several traditional house types were used.

#### **Tools and Technology**

Traditional tools and technology reflect the resources of the regions. Traditional tools were made of stone, antlers, wood, and bone. Such tools were used to build houses, boats, snowshoes, clothing, and cooking utensils. Birch trees were used wherever they were found.

## **Social Organization**

The Athabascans have matrilineal system in which children belong to the mother's clan, rather than to the father's clan, with the exception of the Holikachuk and the Deg Hit'an. Clan elders made decisions concerning marriage, leadership, and trading customs. Often the core of the traditional group was a woman and her brother, and their two families. In such a combination the brother and his sister's husband often became hunting partners for life. Sometimes these hunting partnerships started when a couple married.

Traditional Athabascan husbands were expected to live with the wife's family during the first year, when the new husband would work for the family and go hunting with his brothers-in-law. A central feature of traditional Athabascan life was (and still is for some) a system whereby the mother's brother takes social responsibility for training and socializing his sister's children so that the children grow up knowing their clan history and customs.

## **Clothing**

Traditional clothing reflects the resources. For the most part, clothing was made of caribou and moose hide. Moose and caribou hide moccasins and boots were important parts of the wardrobe. Styles of moccasins vary depending on conditions. Both men and women are adept at sewing, although women traditionally did most of skin sewing.

## **Transportation**

Canoes were made of birch bark, moose hide, and cottonwood. All Athabascans used sleds --with and without dogs to pull them – snowshoes and dogs as pack animals.

## **Trade**

Trade was a principle activity of Athabascan men, who formed trading partnerships with men in other communities and cultures as part of an international system of diplomacy and exchange. Traditionally, partners from other tribes were also, at times, enemies, and travelling through enemy territory was dangerous.

## **Regalia**

Traditional regalia varies from region to region. Regalia may include men's beaded jackets, dentalium shell necklaces (traditionally worn by chiefs), men and women's beaded tunics and women's beaded dancing boots.

**Assignment 1:** Watch the movie Spirit of the Wind. It portrays the life of George Attla up to the year 1979. Be prepared to answer the following questions about the movie and his life:

1. How did George Sr., George's father, run his trap line? That is, what was his means of transportation?
2. What was the source of heat for the family cabin?
3. How did the Attla family buy the goods they couldn't catch, grow, or make themselves?
4. How did the family reach summer fish camp?
5. At what age did George contract tuberculosis?
6. Where did he go for treatment and cure?
7. How long was he away from his home?
8. Where did he attend school while he was being treated for tuberculosis?
9. Where is the Fur Rendezvous World Championship race held?

**Assignment 2:** Go online and read this 2009 article on the making of the movie:

[http://attlamakingofachampion.com/wp-content/uploads/2011/12/2009.10.00-First-Alaskans-Magazine\\_RJ.jpg](http://attlamakingofachampion.com/wp-content/uploads/2011/12/2009.10.00-First-Alaskans-Magazine_RJ.jpg)

**Assignment 3:** Read the newspaper article about George's first Fur Rondy win:

[http://attlamakingofachampion.com/wp-content/uploads/2011/12/1958.02.24-ADT-Attla-Dog-mushing-Champion-COMP\\_RJ.jpg](http://attlamakingofachampion.com/wp-content/uploads/2011/12/1958.02.24-ADT-Attla-Dog-mushing-Champion-COMP_RJ.jpg)

1. Write down the route he took to get from Huslia to the Fur Rondy race site.
2. How many methods of transportation did he use?
3. On a map of Alaska, figure out how many miles he traveled to get to the race.

**Assignment 4:** If you are interested in sled dogs, read the article on the origins of Alaskan sled dogs: [http://www.sleddogcentral.com/features/little\\_wolf/alaskans.htm](http://www.sleddogcentral.com/features/little_wolf/alaskans.htm)

**Assignment 5:** An important piece of Alaska history was made by both non-native and Alaska native mushers: the 1918 serum run from Nenana to Nome. Read the article about the serum run:

**Assignment 6:** Working with sled dogs may have unintended or unexpected benefits. Read the interview of George in Mushing Magazine in which he talks about how working with dogs influenced the way he raised his children: <http://attlamakingofachampion.com/wp-content/uploads/2011/12/2012.03-Mushing-Magazine-Part-II-Attla.pdf>

1. Summarize or describe how he saw the connection.
2. Might there be a similar benefit from raising and training hunting dogs? Pet dogs? Explain in a paragraph or two your reasoning.

**Assignment 7:** Late in life, George used his energies to establish a dog mushing program for middle and high school students in Huslia. This is, perhaps, another unexpected benefit

of working with sled dogs. Read his obituary:

<http://www.adn.com/print/article/20150215/famed-alaska-musher-george-attla-dead-81>

1. Write a paragraph, based on the obituary and perhaps the interview you read, about how the Frank Attla Youth and Sled Dog Care Mushing Program could benefit Alaskan youth. Use your imagination and your understanding about personal accomplishment as it relates to a person's self-image. Please discuss this assignment with your parents. They will have definite ideas to share with you.
2. Develop a short list of activities in which you are or could be involved that might build your confidence and sense of self-worth in a way similar to the mushing program just mentioned in the obituary.

**Assignment 8:** Recall in the movie that when George finally returned to his family and community he had been removed from his culture for almost ten years. He had a different set of experiences than his brother. He knew less about the fish wheel and its operation than his brother. In many respects, he was caught between two cultures due, in part, to his boarding school experience. Read the article on cultural assimilation of Native Americans as background for the next assignment:

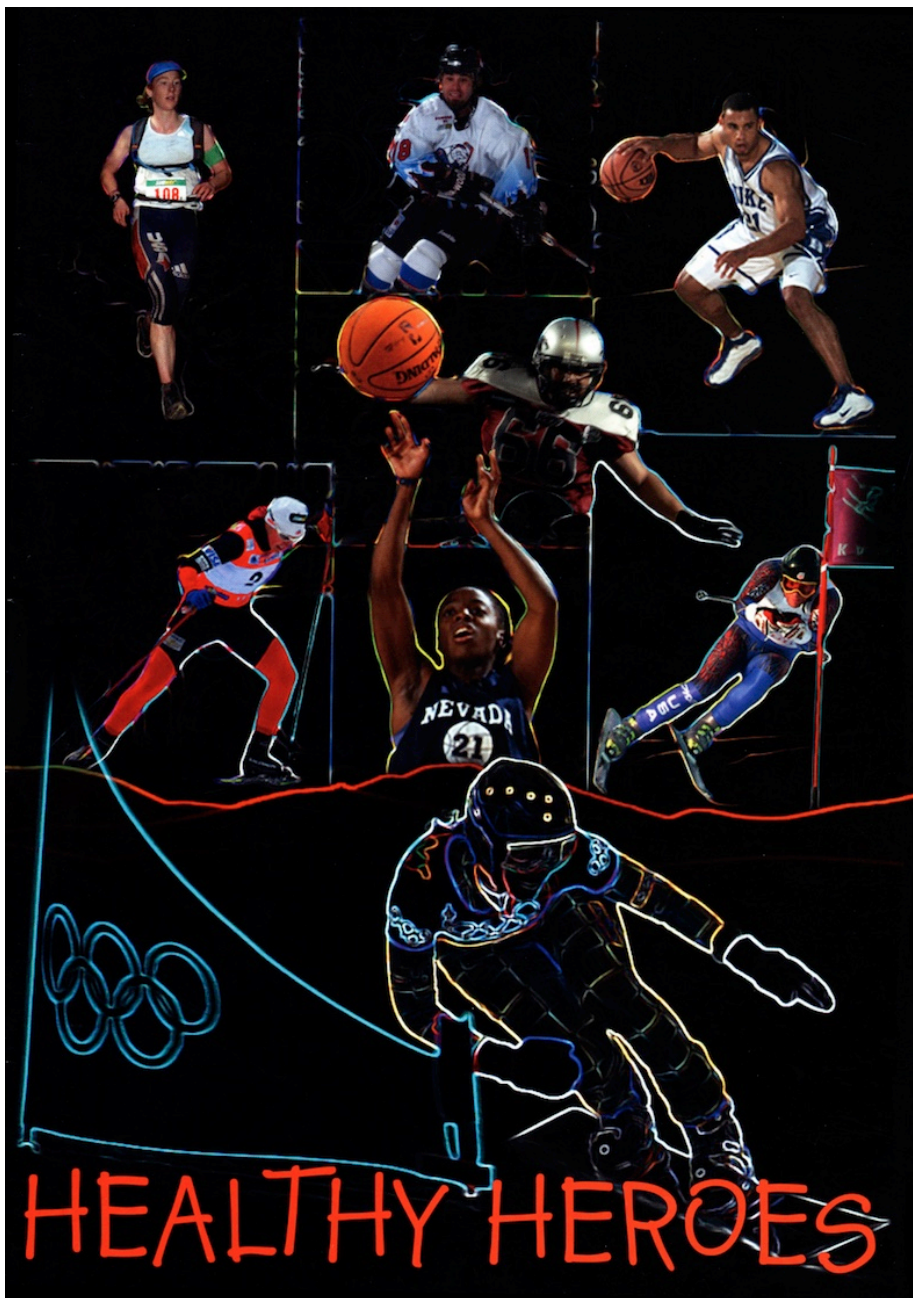
[wikipedia.org/wiki/Cultural\\_assimilation\\_of\\_Native\\_Americans#Non-reservation\\_boarding\\_schools](http://wikipedia.org/wiki/Cultural_assimilation_of_Native_Americans#Non-reservation_boarding_schools)

**Assignment 9:** In the 1960s and, perhaps earlier, Alaska villagers, mostly native, began to push for local village high schools. They were seeking to preserve family and cultural unity. Read *Tobeluk v Lind*, the court case that led to a resolution of this issue:

[wikipedia.org/wiki/Tobeluk\\_v\\_Lind](http://wikipedia.org/wiki/Tobeluk_v_Lind)

See also, the article on the Molly Hootch decision, the legal resolution of the law suit:  
[http://www.alaskool.org/native\\_ed/law/mhootch\\_erq.html](http://www.alaskool.org/native_ed/law/mhootch_erq.html)

1. How many high school-age students does it take to require the state of Alaska to supply a village high school?
2. Who was Molly Hootch?
3. Make a list of five reasons why you might not like to be sent hundreds or thousands of miles away from home to a boarding school.
4. Suggest one potential advantage that might come to you at a boarding school. You might want to write paragraphs to answer these last two challenges.



ConocoPhillips Healthy Futures is a community initiative to provide Alaska's youth with greater access to positive role models in sports through the Healthy Heroes project. Founding partners in the project include the Municipality of Anchorage Parks & Recreation, the Anchorage School District, and the Alaska Association for Health, Physical Education, Recreation & Dance ConocoPhillips Healthy Futures initiative and the Alaska Sports Hall of Fame.

This project would not be possible without the efforts of the outstanding Alaskan athletes who contributed their inspiring messages.

The written submissions have been edited here for space considerations. Visit the Healthy Heroes home at [www.alaskasportshall.org](http://www.alaskasportshall.org) to read the Healthy Hero contributions in their entirety and find out about opportunities to chat online with your favorite Healthy Hero!

*Photos courtesy of Sharbel Dussault, Bob Hill, Erik Hill, Devon Kershaw, Clark James Michler, Eric Teela, Anchorage Daily News, Dallas Morning News, Duke Athletic Department, and the Leadville Times*



**Anchorage School District**  
Educating All Students for Success in Life



**ConocoPhillips**  
**Healthy**  
**FUTURES**

An initiative of the Alaska Association for Health,  
Physical Education, Recreation and Dance  
[www.healthyfuturesak.org](http://www.healthyfuturesak.org)

ANCHORAGE



PARKS & RECREATION

## EXERCISE

I lived in a remote part of Interior Alaska with my family until I was around eight years old when I contracted tuberculosis in my knee and was sent away to a hospital. At that time the only known way to keep use of my leg was to be put in traction, so I was forced to stay in bed and be totally constricted for over a month. My body became very weak from the inactivity. While stuck in a hospital bed, I was pestered by many kids. When I was finally allowed to get up, I was mad and went after the biggest kid. I was shocked that I was so easily beat up. From that time on, I vowed never to let myself get out of shape. I started working to strengthen my upper body by doing pull-ups, push-ups, and sit-ups. After this first attempt to straighten my leg, I went back to the bush and swung a 10 lb birch hammer every morning. In helping my family live off the land, I did many necessary chores like packing wood. By the next year my leg was bent again. I went back in the hospital for more traction and this time I made friends with a janitor, who kept in tremendous shape by using a spring bar and weights. Once again confined to bed I used his bar and weights daily, while continuing to do pulls-ups, sit-ups, and push-ups. At 15 years old after an operation to permanently fuse my knee, I got out of the hospital but stayed in a boarding school for two years where I learned how to box and play basketball to stay fit. I then went back home and kept in shape all winter by setting beaver traps which entailed cutting and chopping ice and snow shoeing, plus I ran a trap-line and hauled wood using dogs. By spring I felt in such good shape that I thought I could whip the world. In summer, I hauled fish nets, cut 400-500 salmon a day, rowed boats, and used a sledge hammer to pound stakes. — **George Attla**

### What do you do on an average day to exercise?

It doesn't matter how long you exercise or what activity you choose for your exercise. It matters that you get out and do it every day! — **Aelin Peterson**

He ran everywhere. If you served under his command in the military, the only time that you were permitted to walk was if you were with a higher ranking officer who was walking. — **Col. Norman Vaughn's wife Carolyn on Norman**

Make sure the activities or sports you choose are fun and enjoyable. Make daily activity a part of your healthy lifestyle. — **Dick Mize**

## EXERCISE

I try to go to the gym five days a week. I lift weights and either ride the bike or run for 40 minutes. — **Dean Larson**

I started forming good habits early on, so now it's no problem for me to work out three times a week from 5:30 to 7:00 a.m. — **Eric Heil**

I carry 20 gallons of water everyday to feed my dogs three times a day plus I pick up after them. In winter I cut and haul all my firewood, shovel snow, travel by snow machine and trap beaver under the ice. In summer I set nets to catch salmon. Basically I move all day, everyday. — **George Attla**

When you have a spare hour and can either choose to watch TV or get in a workout, make the decision that will benefit you the most. — **Karen Patten**

My average day of exercise usually includes two workouts. I start my first workout around 8:00 a.m. and train one to two hours. My second workout is at 4:00 p.m. and ranges from 30 min - 1 hr. — **Kikkan Randall**

You don't have to run marathons. Just walking — something almost all of us can do — is great exercise and a great way to start down the path of being active everyday. — **Kris Thorsness**

Alaskans have an advantage in that the wilderness is usually just out our back door, inviting us out. It is easy to stay healthy when hiking, fishing, berry picking and snow shoveling are part of everyday life. — **Libby Riddles**

I try to make up for my bad eating habits by being very active. Basketball is my favorite sport. I try to play basketball at least two to five times per week. — **Ma'o Tosi**

Everybody uses a car, but I used to run, ski, or bike seven miles to work. I wasn't the best dressed person in the office, but I kept a change of clothes I could get in and out of. — **Stan Justice**

For exercise I play basketball, lift weights and do some long distance jogging. — **Trajan Langdon**

I try to ski a lot and go for walks. Nordic skiing is also fun in the winter. — **Tommy Moe**

I stretch, stretch, stretch, strengthening my body to do anything I want it to, which is important for all of the different type of Alaska Native Games events. I build on my core stretches, adding weights to help gravity push me even further. After all of that work, my hope is that I will continue kicking and jumping for years to come. — **Phillip Blanchett**

